

# Uncertain Signals: Partisan Cues' Asymmetric Effects on Trade Policy Preferences<sup>\*</sup>

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## Abstract

How do citizens form preferences towards specific trade policies? While most Americans express broadly supportive attitudes towards trade in the abstract, preferences over specific trade agreements are far more contested. We argue that partisan cues play a central role in translating general trade attitudes into policy-specific preferences, and that these cues operate asymmetrically: because trade liberalization generates diffuse gains but concentrated losses, negative cues heighten distributional uncertainty while positive cues do comparatively little. Drawing on three survey experiments fielded between 2023 and 2026 in the United States and Australia, we find that negative partisan cues produce substantively meaningful reductions in support for a hypothetical free trade agreement. Positive cues produce no detectable shifts. This asymmetry is specific to trade and highly-polarized political environments: equivalent cues do not move preferences on tax or youth employment policy among US respondents; nor do they move trade policy preferences in Australia, where partisan identity is thinner than in the United States. We theorize that rather than serving as information shortcuts, negative partisan cues on trade policy function as information triggers that activate economic anxiety over the distributional consequences of liberalization.

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# 1 Introduction

How do citizens form preferences towards specific trade policies? Consider the fate of two trade agreements. The North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), whose public support in the U.S. rarely reached above 50% throughout its lifespan,<sup>1</sup> became one of the most vilified policies in American politics. Donald Trump's 2016 campaign called it a "catastrophe" responsible for the loss of "one-third of our manufacturing jobs,"<sup>2</sup> and his 2019 State of the Union address labeled it a "historic trade blunder."<sup>3</sup> Its replacement, the United States-Mexico-Canada Agreement (USMCA), arrived in 2020 to broad public approval: 80% of Americans expected it to benefit the country, compared to just 13% who anticipated harm.<sup>4</sup> What makes this gap in favorability even more striking is the partisan shift: while the USMCA appears remarkably similar to NAFTA in both content and objectives,<sup>5</sup> it was widely embraced by Republicans, whose support jumped from 44% for NAFTA in 2018 to 86% for USMCA in 2019.<sup>6</sup>

This discrepancy in public opinion also extends to voters' general attitude towards trade as a policy issue. While nearly four fifths of Americans express broadly supportive attitudes towards trade in the abstract,<sup>7</sup> preferences over specific trade agreements tell a different story. A 2017 Pew poll found that 39% of Americans believed NAFTA had been bad for the country.<sup>8</sup> More generally, the populist surge since the 2010s, both in the United States and beyond, focused not on opposition to trade as a concept but on hostility towards particular "bad deals" and the institutions that scaffold them.<sup>9</sup> The persistent gap between what citizens think about trade in the abstract and how they evaluate the specific policies through which trade is conducted has remained elusive to explain.

We argue that partisan cues play a critical role in translating general trade attitudes into policy-

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<sup>1</sup>Gallup (2017)

<sup>2</sup>*Remarks at a Rally at the Pensacola Bay Center in Pensacola, Florida | The American Presidency Project* (2023-04-09)

<sup>3</sup>*Remarks by President Trump in State of the Union Address – The White House* (2023-04-09)

<sup>4</sup>Gallup (2020)

<sup>5</sup>Luhby (2019)

<sup>6</sup>Dina Smeltz (Wed, 10/29/2025 - 08:00)

<sup>7</sup>Gallup (2020)

<sup>8</sup>Stokes (2023-04-09)

<sup>9</sup>The Brexit movement, for example, maintained a similar stance, contending that the UK would negotiate more favorable agreements bilaterally after leaving the EU (*Briefing: Trade, Investment and Jobs Will Benefit If We Vote Leave*, 2023-04-09).

specific preferences. When citizens evaluate a particular trade agreement, a complex policy whose distributional consequences are difficult to assess in advance, they turn to signals from partisan elites to guide their assessment. Most importantly, these cues do not operate symmetrically: because trade liberalization generates diffuse gains spread across consumers but concentrated losses that fall heavily on specific communities and workers, negative cues carry more weight than positive ones. A signal that one's own party opposes an agreement, or that the opposing party supports it, heightens distributional anxiety and prompts citizens to ask whether they or their communities might be among those bearing the concentrated costs. A positive cue, by contrast, offers reassurance about benefits that remain abstract and hard to localize. The asymmetry runs in one direction: downward.

We evaluate this argument through a series of three survey experiments. In a first experiment, fielded in March 2023, we randomize the partisan cues that respondents receive about a hypothetical US-UK free trade agreement, varying both the source of the cue (in-party, out-party, or bipartisan) and its direction (support or oppose). A second experiment, fielded in July 2023, replicates the design and extends it to two additional policy domains—tax policy and youth employment—to test whether the asymmetric pattern is specific to trade. A third experiment, fielded in both the United States and Australia from March-April 2026, replicates the broader design across political contexts, to assess the effects of partisan environments on cue credibility.

Across experiments, we find a consistent and substantively meaningful pattern: in the United States' heavily partisan context, negative partisan cues—particularly opposition from one's own party, but frequently bipartisan opposition and support from the opposing party—reduce support for the trade agreement. The equivalent negative cues do not produce comparable effects on tax or youth employment policy, a finding that speaks against the interpretation that the asymmetry reflects a general feature of partisan communication rather than something specific to trade. Positive cues, in contrast, produce no detectable shift in preferences across all contexts. Finally, consistent with our argument that partisan cues generate uncertainty among respondents regarding trade policies' distributional consequence, we also find some evidence showing that respondents who receive negative cues are more likely to seek out additional information about the agreement; these effects, however,

are inconsistent across experiments.

Our article makes two contributions to the study of international political economy of trade. First, we theorize and demonstrate that partisan cues on trade policy operate asymmetrically: only negative cues produce substantively meaningful shifts in preferences. We trace this asymmetry to the distributional structure of trade itself—diffuse gains, concentrated losses—which makes citizens especially receptive to signals that heighten economic uncertainty about who will bear the costs of liberalization. While prior work has documented the influence of partisan cues on trade attitudes (Dür and Schlipphak, 2021; Hicks, Milner and Tingley, 2014; Naoi and Urata, 2013), we are among the first to demonstrate that this influence is fundamentally asymmetric and to identify the distributional mechanism that explains why. Second, we offer an explanation for one of the more puzzling features of contemporary trade politics: the persistent gap between broadly supportive public attitudes towards trade and the increasing political contestation of specific trade agreements. If partisan cues move opinion only downward, then political environments in which negative cues are salient—as during the 2016 campaign, or in the recurring debates over NAFTA—can drive substantial opposition to a trade agreement even among a public that is, in the abstract, favorable towards trade. The gap between attitudes and policy preferences, we argue, is not a survey artifact but a political consequence of asymmetric cue effects.

## **2 Trade Attitude vs. Trade Policy Preference**

### **2.1 Trade Attitude in the Abstract**

What determines how individuals think about trade? Two traditions in International Political Economy offer competing answers. The rationalist tradition, rooted in Open Economy Politics (OEP), holds that material self-interest is the primary driver of trade attitudes; the competing behavioralist literature emphasizes non-material factors instead. While both accounts have advanced our understanding of abstract attitudes toward trade, neither adequately explains how those attitudes translate into preferences over specific trade agreements.

The rationalist tradition contends that trade attitudes are a function of economic position: those

who stand to gain from openness should support it, and those who stand to lose should oppose it.<sup>10</sup> Whether the relevant cleavage runs along factor lines, industry lines, occupations, or firms, the core logic is the same (Rogowski, 2021; Hiscox, 2002; Alt et al., 1996; Scheve and Slaughter, 2001; Owen and Johnston, 2017; Kim, 2017; Lee and Liou, 2022). Work on the distributional consequences of liberalization reinforces this logic: concentrated import shocks generate persistent labor market disruption, providing rational grounds for trade opposition even when the aggregate economy benefits (Autor, Dorn and Hanson, 2016; Jensen, Quinn and Weymouth, 2017; Ballard-Rosa, Goldstein and Rudra, 2023). Yet this tradition rests on an assumption that has received less scrutiny—that material interests map straightforwardly from abstract attitudes onto preferences for specific policies. The near-identical content of NAFTA and the USMCA poses a challenge: the two agreements imply similar distributional consequences, yet public perceptions diverge sharply.<sup>11</sup>

The behavioralist literature argues that trade attitudes are shaped less by pocketbook calculations than by social identities and values. Nationalism, ethnocentrism, and racial attitudes strongly predict hostility toward trade (Mutz, Mansfield and Kim, 2021; Mutz and Kim, 2017/ed), while sociotropic evaluations—beliefs about whether trade benefits the nation or one’s community, rather than oneself—are among the strongest predictors of support (Mansfield and Mutz, 2009; Alkon, 2017; Kertzer et al., N.d.). While the behavioralist account has reoriented the field away from narrow economic self-interest, it faces a similar difficulty in explaining preferences over specific agreements. Social characteristics and values should predict comparable support for NAFTA and the USMCA. What’s more, America’s demographic trajectory since the mid-1990s—rising education levels, increasing diversity—should, if anything, predict growing support for trade liberalization under this framework. The protectionist surge of the late 2010s is hard to reconcile with these expectations.

In sum, both traditions offer well-developed accounts of abstract trade attitudes but share a common limitation: they cannot explain why public opinion diverges so sharply across substantively similar agreements, or why broad pro-trade sentiment coexists with hostility toward specific deals. We draw on both traditions to construct measures of individuals’ prior trade attitudes, while arguing

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<sup>10</sup>Lake (2009); for a critical review of OEP, see Rickard (2021).

<sup>11</sup>See Luhby (2019) and Gallup (2020).

that an additional mechanism—partisan cues—is needed to explain variation in preferences at the agreement level.

## 2.2 From Trade Attitudes to Policy Support

How, then, do individuals form preferences over specific trade agreements? A growing body of work has turned to this question directly, examining public opinion on agreements rather than trade in the abstract. One productive approach focuses on institutional design: [Brutger and Li \(2022\)](#) show that an agreement’s voting rules shape public support, with heterogeneous effects across partisan lines, and [Hahm et al. \(2019\)](#) demonstrate through a conjoint experiment that the design of dispute settlement mechanisms—particularly investor-state dispute settlement—is the single most consequential treaty feature for public attitudes toward the TTIP in Germany. A related strand highlights the role of the trading partner, showing that geopolitical considerations ([Carnegie and Gaikwad, 2022](#)) and target country salience ([Kim et al., 2023](#)) independently shape trade policy preferences.

While these contributions mark a valuable turn toward agreement-level opinion, they share a demanding premise: that the public possesses sufficient knowledge about an agreement’s content for these features to matter. In practice, this assumption is hard to sustain. Contemporary trade agreements are sprawling documents. For example, the USMCA spans 34 chapters and 930 pages – excluding the tariff schedules – and covers areas from intellectual property to environmental protections. [Rho and Tomz \(2017\)](#) demonstrate that most voters do not understand the distributional consequences of trade policy, let alone the institutional architecture of specific agreements. [Guisinger \(2017\)](#) argues that the decline of manufacturing and private-sector unions has made the average American’s relationship with trade increasingly opaque, further thinning the information environment surrounding trade policy. To put it differently, the very features that scholars have identified as shaping agreement-level preferences are largely invisible to the public that is supposed to respond to them.

This gap between the information required and the information available leaves considerable room for partisan cues. When individuals cannot independently assess an agreement’s quality, elite

signals become the more natural avenue for preference formation. We turn next to this mechanism and its implications for trade policy attitudes.

### **3 The Asymmetric Effect of Partisan Cues on Trade Policy Preference**

#### **3.1 When Do Partisan Cues Shape Policy Preferences?**

Under what conditions do partisan cues shape citizens' policy preferences? Research in American politics and international relations points to two conditions as central to cue effectiveness. The first condition is informational: partisan cues are most powerful when citizens lack the knowledge or expertise to evaluate a policy on its own merits. When the costs and benefits of a policy are opaque, citizens turn to elite signals as cognitive shortcuts, using the positions of trusted actors to infer whether a policy is desirable (Lupia and McCubbins, 1998; Lau and Redlawsk, 2001; Kam, 2005). Bullock (2011) demonstrates that when citizens possess even modest policy information, the effects of that knowledge is on par with those of partisan cues. When such knowledge is absent, however, cue effects dominate. This pattern extends to international issues, where the public typically has even less independent knowledge: Guisinger and Saunders (2017) show that across a range of foreign policy domains, the relative influence of partisan versus informational cues depends on how much baseline knowledge the public already holds, with cue effects strongest in low-information areas. In short, informational scarcity is the soil in which partisan cues take root.

The second condition is the degree of polarization: cues are effective to the extent that citizens view political parties as meaningful group identities and trust co-partisan elites to select policies in their interest. As affective polarization has deepened in the United States, partisanship has become less a summary of policy positions and more a social identity that structures how citizens process political information (Iyengar et al., 2019; Dias and Lelkes, 2022; Achen and Bartels, 2016). This polarization creates an asymmetry in trust: citizens are inclined to believe that the party they identify with will pursue policies that benefit them, while the opposing party's preferred policies are viewed with suspicion: less likely to serve their interests, and potentially harmful (Nicholson, 2012). The

deeper the partisan divide, the more citizens rely on party labels rather than policy substance to form their assessments. [Kertzer and Zeitzoff \(2017\)](#) corroborate this logic, showing that trust in the source of a cue is a key moderator of cue uptake across a range of foreign policy issues.

When both conditions are present—citizens lack independent information about a policy and partisan identities are sufficiently salient—the standard expectation is that cues operate symmetrically. Positive cues from a trusted in-party source should increase support, while negative in-party cues should decrease it; out-party cues should have the mirror effect. This symmetric pattern is the baseline prediction of the cue-as-heuristic framework ([Lupia and McCubbins, 1998](#); [Lau and Redlawsk, 2001](#)), and it finds broad empirical support across domestic and international policy domains—from European integration referenda ([Hobolt, 2006](#)) and American ballot initiatives ([Boudreau and MacKenzie, 2014](#)) to foreign policy attitudes spanning the use of force, climate agreements, and trade ([Guisinger and Saunders, 2017](#); [Bechtel et al., 2015](#); [Dür and Schlipphak, 2021](#); [Hicks, Milner and Tingley, 2014](#); [Naoi and Urata, 2013](#)).

Yet there are reasons to expect that cue effects on trade policy depart from this symmetric baseline. [Nicholson \(2012\)](#) provides an early indication: in the American two-party system, out-party cues polarize opinion but in-party cues do not reliably persuade, suggesting that negative signals carry more weight than positive ones. We argue that this asymmetry is especially pronounced in trade policy because of the distinctive distributional structure of trade liberalization. The gains from trade are diffuse—spread across consumers and competitive industries in ways that are difficult for any individual to perceive—while the losses are concentrated, falling heavily on specific communities and workers in import-competing sectors ([Autor, Dorn and Hanson, 2016](#); [Jensen, Quinn and Weymouth, 2017](#)).

This distributional asymmetry matters because it shapes how citizens experience uncertainty about trade. Most individuals cannot determine in advance whether they or their communities will be among the winners or losers of a given trade agreement. The China shock demonstrated that the costs of liberalization can be severe, geographically concentrated, and persistent—devastating local labor markets in ways that few affected workers anticipated ([Autor, Dorn and Hanson, 2016](#)). This



history means that many citizens carry a baseline uncertainty about the distributional consequences of trade: they know that someone will bear concentrated costs, but they cannot easily assess whether it will be them. A negative partisan cue sharpens this uncertainty into anxiety. When a trusted in-party source signals that an agreement is harmful, or when the out-party endorses a deal, citizens are prompted to ask whether this particular agreement might be the one that imposes costs on their community, their industry, or their household. A positive cue, by contrast, offers reassurance about gains that remain abstract and hard to localize—a less compelling signal in an environment already pervaded by distributional uncertainty.

We contend, in other words, that partisan cues on trade policy do not simply serve as information shortcuts that citizens draw on symmetrically. Rather, negative cues function as information triggers: they heighten the salience of distributional uncertainty and spur citizens to reassess their preferences downward. Positive cues, precisely because the benefits of trade are harder to personalize and because citizens have no parallel history of being surprised by unexpected windfalls from liberalization, do comparatively little to move opinion upward. [Bonifai, Malesky and Rudra \(2025\)](#) corroborate this logic from a different context, showing that perceptions of economic risk from globalization can motivate individuals to seek out additional information—a finding that resonates with our argument that negative cues trigger active reassessment rather than passive updating. In sum, we argue that this asymmetry is specific to the distributional structure of trade and should not generalize to policy domains where gains and losses are more evenly distributed or where citizens face less uncertainty about who will be affected.

### **3.2 Partisan Cues in Trade Policy**

Building on the argument developed above, we derive three hypotheses about how partisan cues shape preferences over specific trade agreements. While the standard cue-as-heuristic framework predicts symmetric effects in both directions, the distributional structure of trade—diffuse gains, concentrated losses—leads us to expect that only negative cues will produce substantively meaningful shifts in opinion. We therefore focus on the cue configurations that should reduce support.

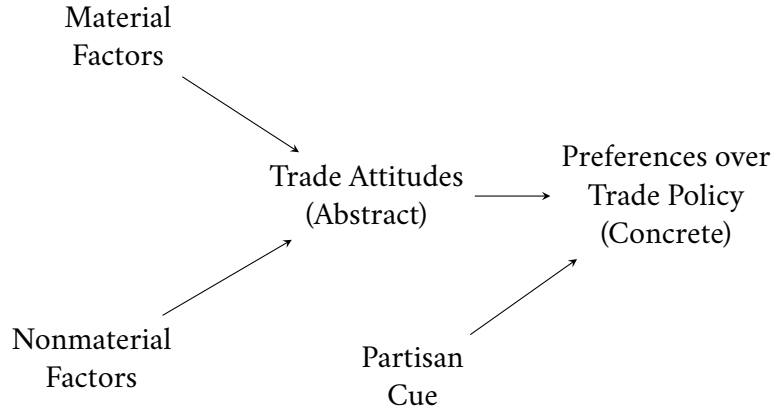


Figure 1: Conceptual model: material and nonmaterial factors shape abstract trade attitudes, which combine with partisan cues to produce policy preferences.

**H<sub>1</sub>:** Receiving a **negative in-party** cue will lead to greater **opposition** to a specific trade agreement.

**H<sub>2</sub>:** Receiving a **positive out-party** cue will lead to greater **opposition** to a specific trade agreement.

**H<sub>3</sub>:** Receiving a **negative bipartisan** cue will lead to greater **opposition** to a specific trade agreement.

We expect negative in-party cues (**H<sub>1</sub>**) to exert the strongest effect, for two reasons. First, co-partisan elites are the actors that citizens trust most to evaluate whether a policy serves their interests (Kertzer and Zeitzoff, 2017). Opposition from a trusted source is difficult to dismiss. Second, and more specific to trade, the signal that one’s own party—the party presumed to be looking out for its base—has concluded that the agreement is harmful activates the distributional uncertainty that citizens already carry. As the China shock demonstrated, the costs of trade liberalization can devastate specific communities and industries in ways that few affected workers anticipate (Autor, Dorn and Hanson, 2016). Most citizens cannot determine ex ante whether they or their communities will bear these concentrated costs. An in-party oppose cue sharpens this latent uncertainty into concrete anxiety: if the party that is supposed to look out for people like me has concluded that this deal is harmful, then perhaps my community, my industry, or my household is among those at risk. The cue,

in effect, transforms a diffuse concern about trade into a personalized signal of distributional threat.

Positive out-party cues ( $H_2$ ) should reduce support through a different channel. In a polarized environment, where partisan identity structures evaluations of policy substance (Nicholson, 2012; Iyengar et al., 2019), learning that the opposing party endorses an agreement functions less as reassurance and more as a warning: if the opposition favors this deal, it is plausible that the deal's benefits flow to their constituents rather than to mine. The uncertainty mechanism operates here as well, though through a distinct pathway. Because citizens already carry baseline uncertainty about how a trade agreement will affect them and their local surroundings, an out-party endorsement heightens the suspicion that the agreement's distributional consequences are tilted against their interests. The diffuse and hard-to-verify nature of trade gains compounds this effect, making it easier for citizens to project concentrated harm onto a deal that the opposing party supports.

The case of negative bipartisan cues ( $H_3$ ) is distinctive. When both parties oppose an agreement, the cue carries an informational weight that transcends the partisan channel: legislators from across the political spectrum—actors with access to briefings, expert analysis, and the agreement's text—have jointly concluded that the deal is undesirable. We stress that this cue should reduce support even though it necessarily involves the out-party taking the same position as one's own party. While out-party agreement on other issues might provoke suspicion or ambivalence, bipartisan opposition provides sufficiently clear information about the agreement's quality to override partisan considerations. What is more, the distributional uncertainty mechanism is at its most potent here. When elites from both sides jointly signal that a deal is harmful, citizens face an unambiguous warning that the agreement's concentrated costs are real and potentially severe. The bipartisan nature of the opposition removes any possibility of dismissing the signal as partisan posturing, leaving citizens with heightened anxiety about whether they and their communities stand among those who will bear the losses. To put it differently, when both parties oppose a trade agreement, citizens receive the strongest possible signal that someone will be hurt by this deal—and they respond accordingly.

We emphasize that our hypotheses do not predict corresponding positive effects. We do not expect positive in-party cues, negative out-party cues, or positive bipartisan cues to produce substantively

meaningful increases in support. The reason follows directly from the distributional logic developed above: the gains from trade are diffuse and abstract, making reassuring cues less compelling than alarming ones. A positive cue—whether from one’s own party, the opposition, or both—offers comfort about benefits that citizens cannot easily localize to their own economic circumstances. Crucially, there is no parallel history of citizens being surprised by unexpected windfalls from trade liberalization. While the China shock left a vivid record of communities devastated by concentrated import competition (Autor, Dorn and Hanson, 2016; Jensen, Quinn and Weymouth, 2017), no equivalent experience has made the diffuse gains from trade similarly salient. Positive cues therefore lack the raw material to trigger distributional anxiety. The asymmetry in our hypotheses is not an oversight but a core prediction of our theory.

Cues about trade policy can reach citizens through multiple channels—media framing, opinion commentary, conversations with co-partisans. We focus on cues from Congressional party elites for two reasons. First, in the context of a trade agreement awaiting ratification, legislators are the actors with both the most direct access to information about the agreement’s content and the greatest institutional stake in its outcome. Second, party elites maintain a high degree of credibility with co-partisan citizens, making their signals more likely to be taken as authoritative assessments of agreement quality rather than as noise. We therefore design our experiment around cues attributed to Congressional Democrats and Republicans.

In addition to the core outcomes of interest—the effects of negative cues on agreement support—we maintain a secondary outcome of interest: the effect of negative cues on information seeking, which we present below as **H<sub>4</sub>**. We expect that individuals who receive negative cues to internalize the cue as an “information trigger,” and thus be more likely to seek out information about the agreement to better understand its potential distributional effects. We argue that, under the same logic as above, positive cues should not trigger information seeking behavior, as individuals have less reason to worry about the consequences of the agreement’s distributional impact.

**H<sub>4</sub>:** Receiving a **negative cue** will lead to an increased likelihood of **seeking further informa-**

tion.<sup>12</sup>

## 4 Core Experiment: Design

To test our theory and hypotheses, we deployed a novel survey experiment, carried out in March 2023 through Harvard’s Digital Lab for the Social Sciences (DLABSS).<sup>13</sup> Our effective sample in this experiment is  $n = 964$ . Our treatment and control groups were approximately balanced on relevant covariates. For more on our sample balance, see Appendix Fig. 1.

The experiment centered around a hypothetical Free Trade Agreement between the United States and the United Kingdom. The United Kingdom was selected for its status as a clear ally of the United States and as a legitimate candidate for a bilateral FTA, following the Brexit referendum in 2020. Further, it stands to reason that as a large economy and well-known country, American political parties would be likely to take a visible stance on the agreement.<sup>14</sup>

All respondents were given the following prompt:

*“The United States has finished negotiating a free trade agreement with the United Kingdom. The agreement will now go to Congress, which will vote to either ratify—accepting the terms of agreement—or reject the agreement. The agreement would reduce tariffs and protective barriers on consumer goods in both countries. As a result, it is expected that the agreement will increase trade between the U.S. and the U.K. The agreement also regulates investment, intellectual property, and environmental protection in both countries.”*

One-seventh of respondents were presented with no more information about the agreement than above. The remaining respondents were then randomly assigned a treatment across two dimensions: the source of a partisan cue, and the direction (supportive of the agreement or opposed to the agreement). For example, the “Republican Support” prompt read *“Most Congressional Republicans support*

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<sup>12</sup>This hypothesis, along with  $H_1$ ,  $H_2$ , and  $H_3$ , was pre-registered ahead of our second wave of fielding in Summer 2023.

<sup>13</sup>DLABSS maintains a volunteer, opt-in panel of survey respondents. Despite being an opt-in panel, DLABSS performs comparably to paid services like Lucid and Amazon’s Mechanical Turk. For more on DLABSS, see [Strange et al. \(2019\)](#)

<sup>14</sup>[Dür and Schlipphak \(2021\)](#) use a similar logic for the TTIP.

| Treatment Conditions |                    |                    |
|----------------------|--------------------|--------------------|
| Democratic Support   | Republican Support | Bipartisan Support |
| Democratic Oppose    | Republican Oppose  | Bipartisan Oppose  |

Table 1: Experimental treatment conditions: three partisan source configurations (Democrat, Republican, Bipartisan) crossed with direction (support vs. oppose). Respondents randomized into one of seven conditions; the six above, and a control.

*ratifying the agreement.*" The remaining cases were: "Democratic Support," "Democratic Oppose," and "Republican Oppose." Some respondents instead received a bipartisan prompt, which read: *"Most Congressional Democrats and Congressional Republicans support/oppose ratifying the agreement."*

The prompt is designed to give respondents a view of the agreement at the stage where their assessment of the agreement's quality would have the greatest impact on whether the agreement becomes law. Were the agreement still under negotiation, the terms of the agreement would be nebulous and fluid, with less ability for respondents to assess the agreement's quality. Moreover, the mid-negotiation would be under the purview of the US Trade Representative and, more broadly, the Executive Branch, giving individuals less leverage over whether the agreement will be enacted than when the agreement's fate lies with Congress. On the other hand, were the hypothetical agreement already ratified, there would be little need for parties to cue their voters and curry broad favor for the agreement. Under this construction, respondents' opinions about the agreement would have the most leverage, making this the optimal time for parties to cue the public about the agreement's quality.

The prompt also sought to give respondents a short summary of the agreement's content. A key logic in the elite cuing literature is the idea that elites have a greater degree of information than the public in low-information issue areas. We expected respondents to know that trade agreements generally lead to an increase in trade—both on the intensive and extensive margin—between signatories. However, as trade agreements have become more complex, often including a multitude of chapters on behind-the-border regulatory issues, we included references to how the agreement would regulate investment, intellectual property, and environmental protection. We used the term "regulate" to minimize respondents' understanding of what those chapters would do, so as to avoid priming respondents to be more positive or negative about the agreement simply through the inclusion of those

chapters. Further, this would make the lower degree of information that individuals have about the agreement more salient, mirroring the complex reality of assessing trade agreement quality.

In the treatments, we used the language of “Congressional Democrats” and “Congressional Republicans” in order to avoid invoking individual leaders or other polarizing figures in the parties, which could induce bias in the way respondents take up the cue treatment. Moreover, we focused on Congressional party members because the prompt mentions that the agreement would go to Congress, meaning that this is the group with the most direct control over whether the agreement will become law, making their assessment more important than other potential elite commentators. We also chose to include the language of “Most” for realism, allowing the parties to have imperfect discipline on issues as charged as trade. With that said, the broader takeaway from the cue is clear: most of those (from one party/both parties) who have been briefed on the agreement’s content and likely effects, and those who will decide to ratify or reject the agreement, perceive it to be good (bad).

Respondents’ preferences for the FTA were measured across five dimensions, using 7-point Likert scale: support for the agreement, belief that agreement would benefit America, belief that the agreement would benefit them, belief that the agreement would benefit their local community, and belief that the agreement would cause employment or unemployment. Additionally, we collected pre-treatment attitudes towards trade in the abstract, following from prior work in both the OEP and behavioralist tradition. These attitudes include: belief that the US should trade more with other countries; belief that the US would benefit from trading more with other countries; belief that they would benefit from the US trading more with other countries; belief that people like them would benefit from trading more from other countries; and belief that their local community would benefit from the US trading more with other countries. We then created index variables of pre-treatment attitudes for our analysis. All likerts were scaled from  $-3$  to  $3$ , with  $0$  for the neutral midpoint. To control for potential results driven by prior feelings about the United Kingdom,<sup>15</sup> we also asked respondents to complete a feeling thermometer about the United Kingdom, as well as the other UN Security Council permanent members (China, France, and Russia) to avoid potential priming effects

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<sup>15</sup>Carnegie and Gaikwad (2022), Brutger and Li (2022)

prior to treatment.

In addition to the standard age, race, and education battery of covariates, we collected a number of other relevant covariates, across political, social, and economic dimensions. Along the political dimension, respondents were asked to provide their political affiliation and self-reported political leaning; 2012, 2016, 2020 Presidential vote and 2022 midterm party support; and a feeling thermometer to measure warmth of feelings for both parties, which we use as a proxy for receptivity a cue from that sender. In the economic dimension, we collected information on respondent income, employment status, occupation, sector of employment, union status, and if relevant, union of membership. In the social dimension, respondents provided their ZIP codes and assessment of their community as urban, suburban, or rural.

We also sought to evaluate the information sources respondents sought out to learn more about trade agreements. In doing so, we exposed respondents to an opt-in information board following the survey’s completion. After completing the demographic battery at the end of the survey, respondents were told that they were finished with the survey and free to leave; however, if they wanted to learn more about America’s trade agreements, these authors had collected a number of articles, statements, and projections about a recent US Trade Agreement (The 2012 U.S.-Korea Free Trade Agreement, or KORUS) for them to peruse. We included an article from Reuters (centrist/informational), the New York Times (left-leaning), and Fox News (right-leaning), as well as statements from Business Leaders, Union Leaders, and projections from Economists about the agreement’s expected effects.<sup>16</sup> A total of 484 respondents (50%) clicked on at least one link on the Information Board. We discuss our analysis of the Information Board in Section 6.

## 5 Core Experiment: Results

We theorize that two elements of partisan cues jointly shape individuals’ preference toward specific trade agreements: the *source* (in-group/out-group/bipartisan cues) and the *direction* (supportive/opposing cues) of partisan cues. Therefore, with slight abuses of notation, we estimate the effect

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<sup>16</sup>For more detail on the contents of the Information Board, see Appendix.



of partisan cues on individuals' preference toward the US-UK agreement using the following linear regression:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{SOURCE}_i \times \text{DIRECTION}_i) + \sum_{k=2}^K \beta_k X_{ki} + \epsilon_i \quad (1)$$

in which  $X$  represents a  $i \times k$  covariate matrix, for which a summary of the descriptive statistics can be found in table A.1. In addition, `SOURCE` is a categorical variable computed by interacting treated respondents' party ID with the party they receive in the survey prompt. Similarly, `DIRECTION` is a binary variable denoting whether the treated respondent received a prompt that indicates support or opposition toward the trade agreement. Taken together, the interaction between `SOURCE` and `DIRECTION` uniquely identifies whether a respondent is assigned to the control group, or to one of the six treatment groups. Therefore, we can estimate six sets of coefficients that document the treatment effects of partisan cues. Figure 2 visualizes the point estimates of treatments on binary outcomes<sup>17</sup> as well as the 95% confidence intervals for each treatment group:

As shown in fig. 2, the survey experiment confirms half of our original hypotheses: Respondents who receive (1) an in-party oppose cue; (2) a bipartisan oppose cue; or (3) an out-party support cue have a significantly reduced level of support for the U.S.-U.K. trade agreement. More specifically, an in-party oppose cue reduces a respondent's likelihood to support the agreement by 22% ( $\sim 0.57$  standard deviation of the outcome variable); a bipartisan oppose cue reduces a respondent's likelihood to support the agreement by 15% ( $\sim 0.38$  sd); and an in-party oppose cue reduces a respondent's likelihood to support the agreement by 10% ( $\sim 0.26$  sd). In contrast, the preferences among respondents who receive other cues (in-party support, bipartisan support, or out-party oppose) are statistically indistinguishable from the respondents who did not receive any partisan cues. In other words, the experiment finds empirical support *only* for the hypotheses that propose a *negative* effect. Table A.2 presents the full result of our regression analysis.

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<sup>17</sup>The binary outcomes are coded by dichotomizing the responses from the original Likert (seven-point) scale. Figure A.5 in the appendix shows that the result is robust to the various measurements of the outcome variables

### Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support

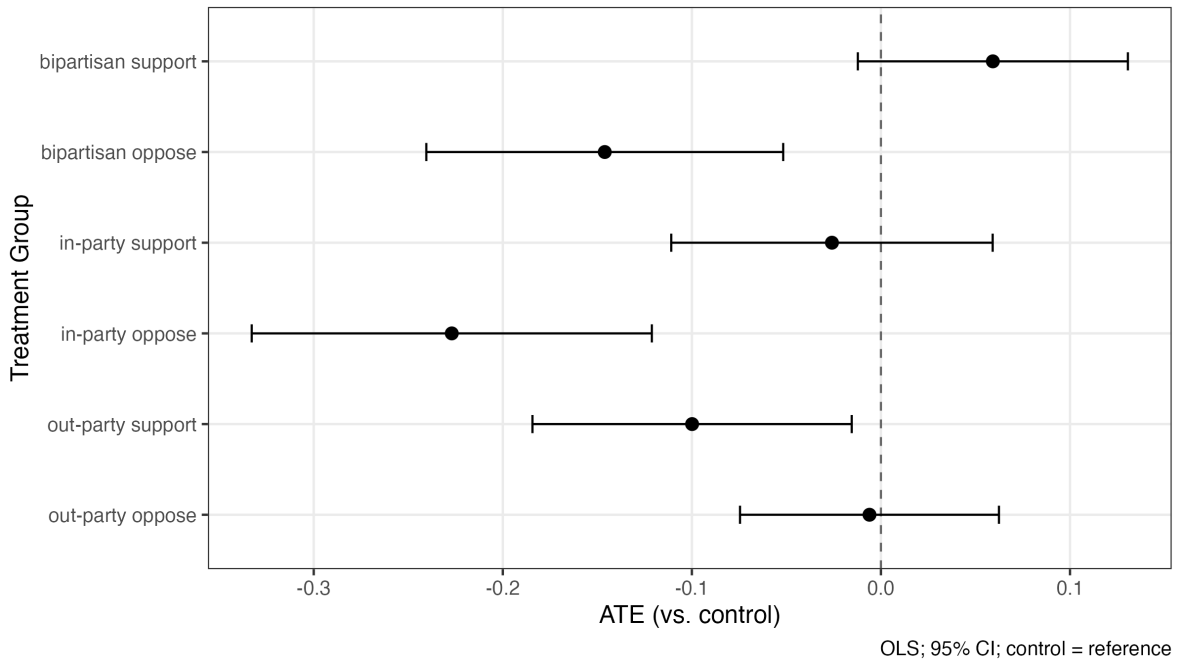


Figure 2: Effects of Partisan Cues on Trade Agreement Preferences

### Partisan Cue ATE on Benefit Beliefs

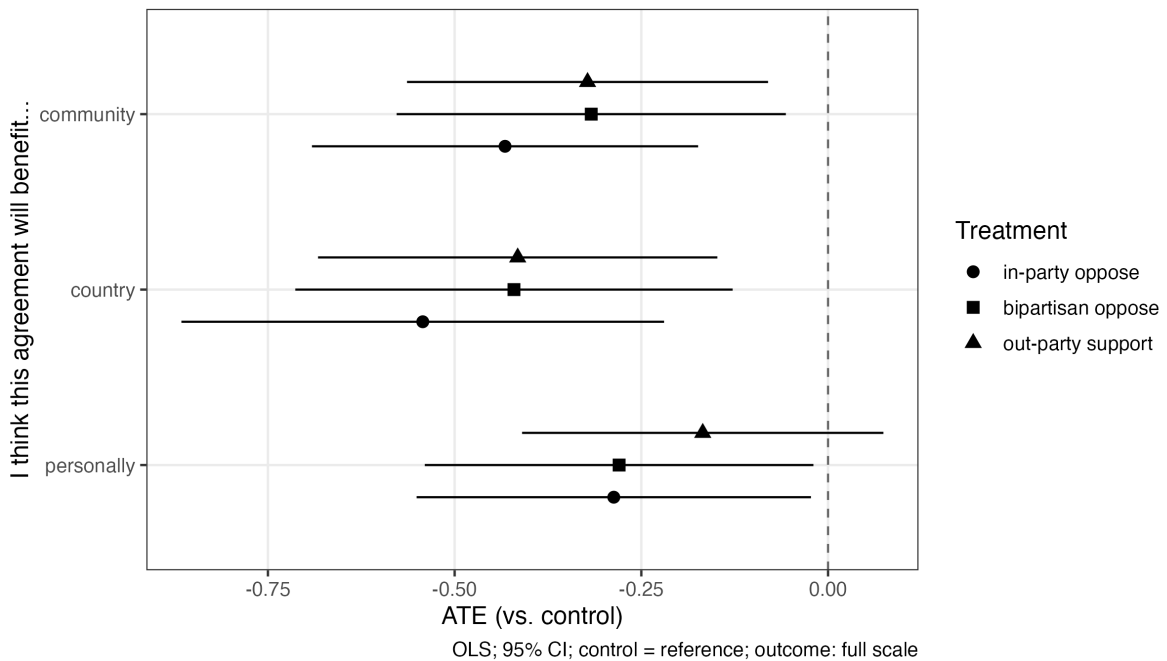


Figure 3: Effects of Partisan Cues on Respondents' Belief of Agreement Impact

While it is possible that the asymmetric effects of partisan cues may result from a potential ceiling effect—about 80% of the respondents indicate that they either somewhat support, support, or greatly support ratifying the agreement—a similar pattern is found when we decompose the information encoded in the partisan cues. Figure 3 visualizes the effects of partisan cues on respondents’ beliefs about the agreement’s potential impact. Despite the baseline responses for these questions being lower than the average support for the agreement in general, respondents who receive a negative cue (i.e., in-party oppose, bipartisan oppose, or out-party support) are significantly less likely to believe that the trade agreement benefits themselves, their local communities, as well as the US as a whole. Conversely, as expected, the positive cues do not alter respondents’ beliefs regarding the potential effects of the trade agreement.

## 6 Decomposing Cue Effects: Information Seeking and Partisan Environment

### 6.1 Effect on Information Seeking

In this section, we briefly turn our attention to the secondary outcome of interest: the effect of negative cues on information seeking.  $H_4$  posits that individuals who receive negative cues will be more likely to seek out information about trade agreements to better understand the distributional effects.

The information board included in our experiment provides an initial test for the above hypotheses. Figure 4 provides the result of a series of t-tests between the control group and treatment groups. The outcome variable is a binary variable indicating whether the respondent searched for at least one piece of information provided to them. The results partially support the information trigger hypothesis ( $H_4$ ), as respondents who receive the in-party oppose or out-party support prompts were more likely to search for additional information (11% and 9%, respectively). These results are significant at  $p < 0.1$  ( $p = 0.06$  and  $p = 0.09$ ).

To further evaluate our theoretical mechanism about the uniqueness of partisan cues in the realm of trade policy, we propose:<sup>18</sup>

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<sup>18</sup>Likewise, this hypothesis was pre-registered ahead of the second wave of fielding in the summer of 2023.

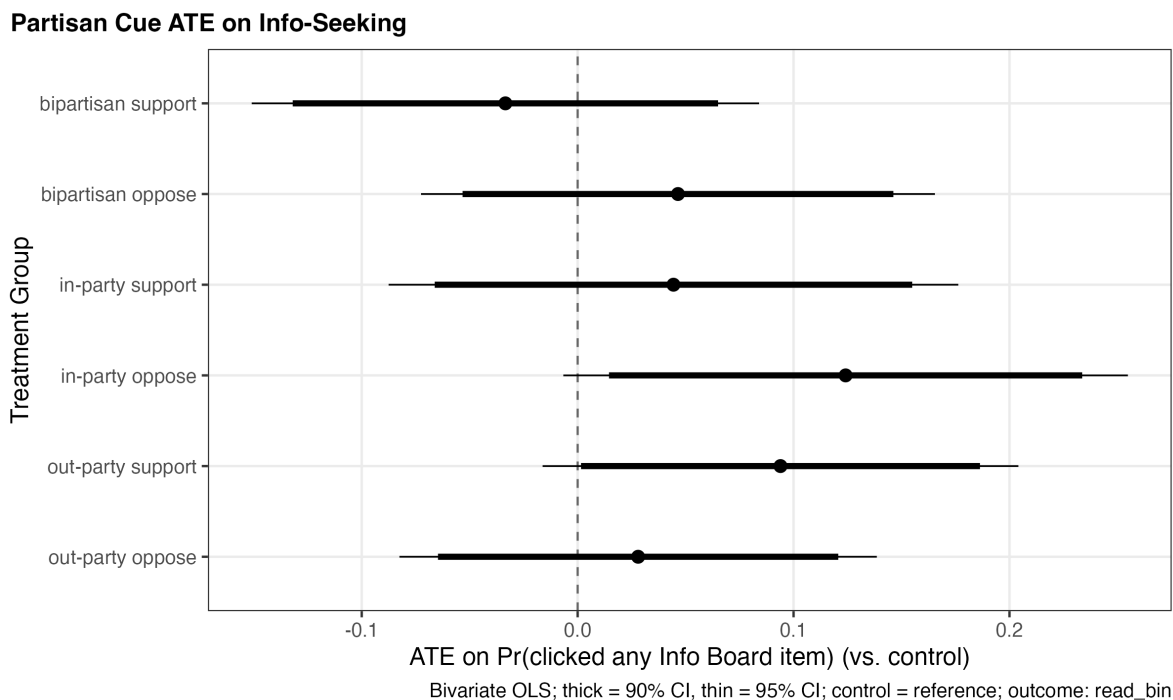


Figure 4: Effects of Partisan Cues on Information Search

**H<sub>5</sub>** (Uniqueness of Trade Policy): Partisan cues affect respondents' preferences towards distributive policies differently across issue areas.

To more directly evaluate our theory about the disparity between positive and negative partisan cues in trade policy, and evaluate the uniqueness of partisan cues in trade policy vs. other policies, we conducted a second survey with a similar yet distinct experimental treatment. Our second survey was also conducted on the DLABSS platform, in mid-July of 2023. Our effective sample is  $n = 974$ .

Our second survey exposed respondents to information about three different policies, varying the received partisan cue across respondents. The three policies of exposure were: trade policy, tax policy, and youth employment policy. All respondents were given the following three prompts:

**Trade:** *“The United States has finished negotiating a free trade agreement with Japan. The agreement will now go to Congress, which will vote to either ratify—accepting the terms of agreement—or reject the agreement. The agreement would reduce tariffs and protective barriers on consumer goods in both countries. As a result, it is expected that the agreement will increase*

*trade between the U.S. and Japan."*

**Tax:** *"Congress has finished debating and is preparing to vote on a bill that would cut income taxes by 2% for all households earning less than \$100,000 per year."*

**Youth Employment:** *"Currently, many states in the US currently require employers to obtain a permit when hiring youth workers under the age of 16. Congress has finished debating and is preparing to vote on a bill that would relax youth labor regulations, meaning that employers would no longer have to apply for a permit to hire workers 14 years old and above."*

Those receiving the control saw no more than the above text, for all three policies. Among the treated, respondents were given one of four treatment arms for each experiment. Unlike in our first survey, which—save for the Bipartisan treatments—exposed respondents to a unidirectional cue from just one party, we chose here to expose all treated respondents to a cue from both major parties. This affords us greater statistical leverage by shrinking the treatment conditions from 6 to 4, while making explicit the implication that “one party supports, the other likely opposes.” Thus, the language for each of the treatments read: *“Most Congressional Democrats [support/oppose] the bill, and most Congressional Republicans [oppose/support] the bill.”* and *“Most Congressional Democrats and Congressional Republicans [support/oppose] the bill.”*

| Treatment Conditions (Second Survey)  |                    |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------|
| Democratic Support, Republican Oppose | Bipartisan Support |
| Republican Support, Democratic Oppose | Bipartisan Oppose  |

Respondents received the trade policy prompt first, then answered a handful of questions about the policy. The post-treatment questions were as follows:

1. *“Would you support Congress passing this proposed law?”*
2. *“Do you think **the US** will benefit from or be harmed by this proposed law?”*
3. *“Do you think that **you** will benefit from or be harmed by this proposed law?”*
4. *“Do you think that **your local community** will benefit from or be harmed by this proposed law?”*
5. *“Do you think this proposed law will **increase employment** (more jobs) or **decrease***

**employment** (*fewer jobs*) in the US?"

6. "Thinking about this proposed law from a **moral point of view**, do you think this law is right or wrong?"

Respondents then received the tax prompt and accompanying follow-up questions, then the labor prompt and its follow-up questions. For each of these questions save for morality, respondents selected from a 7-point Likert scale, with responses ranging from "Strongly support-Strongly oppose," "Entirely benefit-Entirely harmed," and "Increase employment by a lot-Decrease employment by a lot." For morality, they selected from a five-point scale, ranging from "Very right-Very wrong."

We selected tax policy and youth employment policy as alternative policies to test the effects of partisan cues, as they help provide clear tests of our hypotheses about how triggering economic uncertainty is the mechanism through which negative cues affect preferences over trade policy. As discussed above, the negative distributive consequences of trade agreements are concentrated, while the gains are diffuse, and due to the complicated nature of international trade, it stands to reason that the public has a more difficult time interpreting how trade will affect them. In turn, a negative cue about the agreement could signal to the respondent that *they* might be among those bearing the concentrated costs. We contrast this logic with tax policy, whereby respondents can much more clearly evaluate ex ante whether they will be positively or negatively affected by the tax cut; respondents know whether they fall above or below the \$100,000 income line, and thus are more certain about the affect of the policy on *them*. The partisan cue still tells recipients that the party thinks the policy would be overall positive/negative for the country, but the cue weakens as a heuristic for interpreting the projected effect on the individual. The youth employment prompt takes a different angle, as loosening restrictions on youth employment is a policy area where individuals' preferences are guided by self-held moral principles. Further, individuals can reasonably assume that they will not experience any noticeable distributive gain or loss as a result of loosened youth employment regulations, making a negative cue less informative about distributive consequences. While a partisan cue may signal that the party thinks this legislation overall would be good policy, it is less likely to move respondents from their moral-oriented preference. Thus, a negative cue for either tax and youth employment policies

should do little to stimulate economic uncertainty in respondents, allowing us to test the effects of our uncertainty mechanism.

## 6.2 Effect of Partisanship

To assess the effects of partisanship and the partisan environment on cue uptake, we conducted a third survey in both the United States and Australia. We fielded this survey via the Dynata platform in both the United States and Australia between March 26th and April 6th, 2026, yielding a  $n = 1013$  responses in Australia and  $n = 1006$  responses in the United States. Though fielded via Dynata, the survey itself was hosted on Harvard's Qualtrics platform.

Dynata maintains a global panel of web-based survey respondents across 82 countries. Respondents are invited to take surveys via email, and receive compensation—tied to survey length and complexity—for their time. Only individuals 18 years old or older are eligible to participate; only respondents with verified IP addresses in the country under examination are eligible as well. To ensure response quality, we included a combination of attention check questions, the former serving as a pure screener.<sup>19</sup> For more on Dynata, see [Peer et al. \(2022\)](#).

The US survey serves as our base case—a replication of the effects of partisan cues on trade policy preferences in a polarized environment marked by affect. Australia stands in as an alternative partisan environment, where partisanship is more weakly-held and less affectively charged.<sup>20</sup> This serves as a test of the uniqueness of partisan cues in the *American* trade policy context. We argue that the effect of partisan cues should be weaker in Australia than in the United States, as individuals are less tightly-tied to their partisan identity in Australia, diminishing the potency of a the cue's signal. From this conjecture, we propose:<sup>21</sup>

**H<sub>6</sub>:** Trade-related partisan cues are weaker in Australia than the United States.

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<sup>19</sup>The screener was as follows: "Of the colors listed below, which of the following is your favorite? This is an attention check – please select "Blue". The attention check question asked respondents to recall the negotiating partner country—Japan—from a list of France, Japan, the United Kingdom, and China. Respondents were asked the attention check question after completing the collected dependent variables section of the survey, approximately two minutes of questions between treatment and check.

<sup>20</sup>See [Silver \(2022\)](#) and [McKinnon Poll: Understanding Partisanship, Polarisation and Social Cohesion in Australia 2024](#) (N.d.) on party identity, and [Martínez Arranz, Zech and Bonotti \(2024\)](#) on affective charge.

<sup>21</sup>This hypothesis was pre-registered ahead of our third wave of fielding in Spring 2026.

We selected Australia as our alternative case for a number of reasons. For one, as discussed above, Australia's partisan environment is thinner and less charged than America's; this is a crucial component of the test. Australia's political system also operates a de facto two-party system. While third parties are present, it has historically been dominated by the center-left Labor and center-right Liberal parties. This lets this structural component of the Australian electoral environment mirror the United States.

Australia also acts as a reasonable socio-economic mirror for the US, as a wealthy, developed, English-speaking liberal market economy. Australia is, however, demonstrably less populous than the US, approximately 12 times smaller, with a population roughly the size of Texas.<sup>22</sup> A blemish in the tightness of this mirroring is Australia's historic relationship with trade. While Australia—like the United States—maintains a robust service economy, it also is heavily reliant on trade; in 2024, trade's share of Australian GDP was 47%, nearly double that of the United States.<sup>23</sup> This potentially raises the average Australian's familiarity with trade, as well as their potential latent preference for facilitating increased trade, as Australia relies more on exports<sup>24</sup> than the US for economic growth.

Our original plan was to use Canada as the alternative, as Canada also meets those same characteristics—a wealthy, developed, English-speaking liberal market economy with thinner and less affective partisanship the United States. However, the geopolitical tensions of the second Trump era has made decoupling from the United States—Canada's largest trade partner—an issue of top priority in both Ottawa and in Canadian mass opinion. This decoupling has seen Canada open trade negotiations with additional countries, namely China.<sup>25</sup> Given that trade and particularly trade agreements has taken on a particular charge in Canada, we opted for Australia instead.

We deploy the same design structure in both countries as the original experiment: respondents were told only about the stance of one of the major parties in the non-bipartisan conditions, unlike

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<sup>22</sup>See *National, State and Territory Population, September 2025 | Australian Bureau of Statistics (2026)* for population statistics.

<sup>23</sup>See *Trade as a Share of GDP (2026)* for measure. Collected via national statistical organizations, OECD national accounts, and World Bank staff estimates.

<sup>24</sup>Particularly in raw materials; Australia retains a robust mining industry, and the bulk of its exports are unfinished goods: metals, minerals, and ores.

<sup>25</sup>See *Steven (2026)* for more on Canada's new trade negotiations.



in Experiment 2 which explicitly balanced support and opposition between the parties. Borrowing from Experiment 2, this experiment uses Japan as the country with whom the US and Australia are negotiating a full Free Trade Agreement.<sup>26</sup>

We also, like Experiment 1, provided respondents with an information board, to assess whether they were made more likely to seek out information about trade agreements after receiving a negative cue. In the US context, we use the same information board as in Experiment 1. In Australia, we use the same structure, but with different sourcing: centrist (The Sydney Morning Herald), left-wing (The Guardian), and right-wing (The Herald Sun) media sources, as well as economists' projections, and statements from labor and business leaders. We provide links to the sources in the Appendix. Like in the US context, we provide information regarding Australia's FTA with South Korea. In the US, 43.6% of the sample clicked on the infoboard; in Australia, 36.3% clicked on the infoboard.

## 7 Uncertainty and Partisan Environment: Results

### 7.1 Uncertainty Experiment

The results of our second experiment demonstrate support for our proposed mechanism ( $H_5$ ). Figure 5 visualizes a series of t-tests between the control and treatment groups. The outcome variable is a binary indicator of support for the prompted policy, with respondents indicating any degree of support receiving a 1 and all others receiving a 0. As predicted by our theory about triggered economic uncertainty serving as the mechanism, the treatments that should stimulate economic uncertainty—a negative in-party cue or a positive out-party cue—demonstrate statistically significant differences in support than the control condition. In no other treatment, across all three issues, do we see statistically significant differences in support between treated and control groups.

In addition to providing support for our proposed mechanism underwriting the uniqueness of partisan cues about trade policy, these results also replicate the findings of our first experiment: re-

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<sup>26</sup>The United States and United Kingdom agreed to a framework for a trade agreement—the “the US-UK Economic Prosperity Deal”—in June 2025; to avoid confusing respondents, we shifted the country to Japan. Australia and Japan have previously signed a joint economic partisanship agreement in 2015; this is smaller than a free trade agreement, the focus of this experiment.

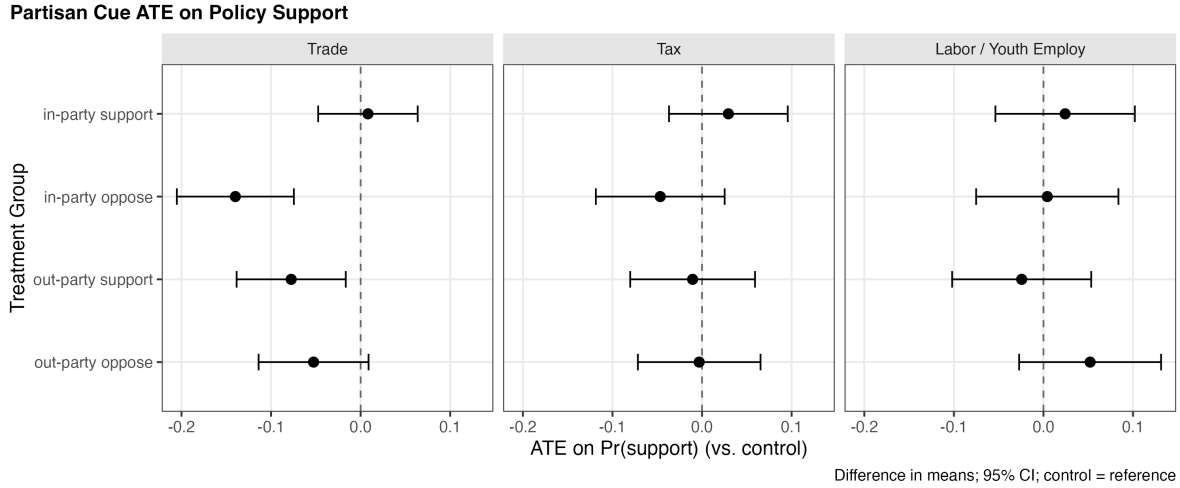


Figure 5: Effect of Partisan Cue Type by Policy Treatment

spondents are only moved by cases that we predict would make them more hostile to the agreement—when their preferred party opposes the agreement, and when their opposition party supports the agreement. These results replicate under a design with a different country—here Japan, rather than the United Kingdom—helping to alleviate potential concerns about the racial/ethnic composition [Mutz, Mansfield and Kim \(2021\)](#) or other country-specific characteristics [Kim et al. \(2023\)](#) of the trading partner. Japan also serves as a reasonably clean stand-in for the United Kingdom, as a large advanced economy, clear US security ally, and well-known country with whom a proposed trade agreement would likely draw public comment from legislators.

It is important to note that the results from Figure 4 fold the bipartisan treatments in with polarized party cues. Individuals thus received two classifications. A democrat, for instance, who received a “Bipartisan Support” cue would be classified as both “In-group support” and “Out-group support.” A Republican receiving “Republican Support Democrat Oppose” would be considered “In-group support” and “Out-group oppose.” This allows us to increase the statistical power of our analysis. While this is a near direct replication of our prior findings, the differences in subgroups as a result of our experimental design prevent these findings from serving as a 1-to-1 replication.

## 7.2 Partisan Context Experiment

On the whole,  $H_6$ —that trade related partisan cues are weaker in Australia than the United States—is supported by the evidence from the third experiment. We present results for the United States in Figure 6 and Australia in Figure 7. In the US context, we replicate our previous findings for in-party opposition: respondents were shifted approximately 11.4 percent on a binarized scale vs. the control (significant at  $p < 0.05$ ). Notably, neither bipartisan opposition or out-party support were significant in this experiment, meaning we do not replicate the findings from that dimension of Experiments 1 and 2 here.

In Australia, however, we see null effects across the board. In addition to the null effects, the point estimate for in-party opposition represents less than 2/3 of the effect size in the United States, at 0.071.<sup>27</sup> These results are robust to recoding the outcome variable from binary to a three-level cardinal coding, with either oppose coded as  $-1$ , neither support nor oppose as 0, and either support as 1. We present equivalent plots for the cardinal DV in Figure A.2 and Figure A.3.<sup>28</sup>

We were unable to replicate the effect of negative cues on information-seeking behavior from the first experiment. Respondents were no more likely to seek additional information from our in-foboard after receiving any cue vs. the control, in both the United States and Australia.<sup>29</sup> This result is unsurprising in Australia, where a cue from a more weakly-associated partisan source was expected to generate little uncertainty-inducement and thus less subsequent information seeking. This result does not support our previously-observed pattern in the United States, and weakens evidence of  $H_{4b}$ .

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<sup>27</sup>These results mesh with Culpepper and Lee (2021), who found that Australians in a banking scandal context were similarly unmoved by partisan cues.

<sup>28</sup>For the full regression table, see Table A.4.

<sup>29</sup>See Figure A.6 for US and Figure A.7 for Australia.

### Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support (binary) (US)

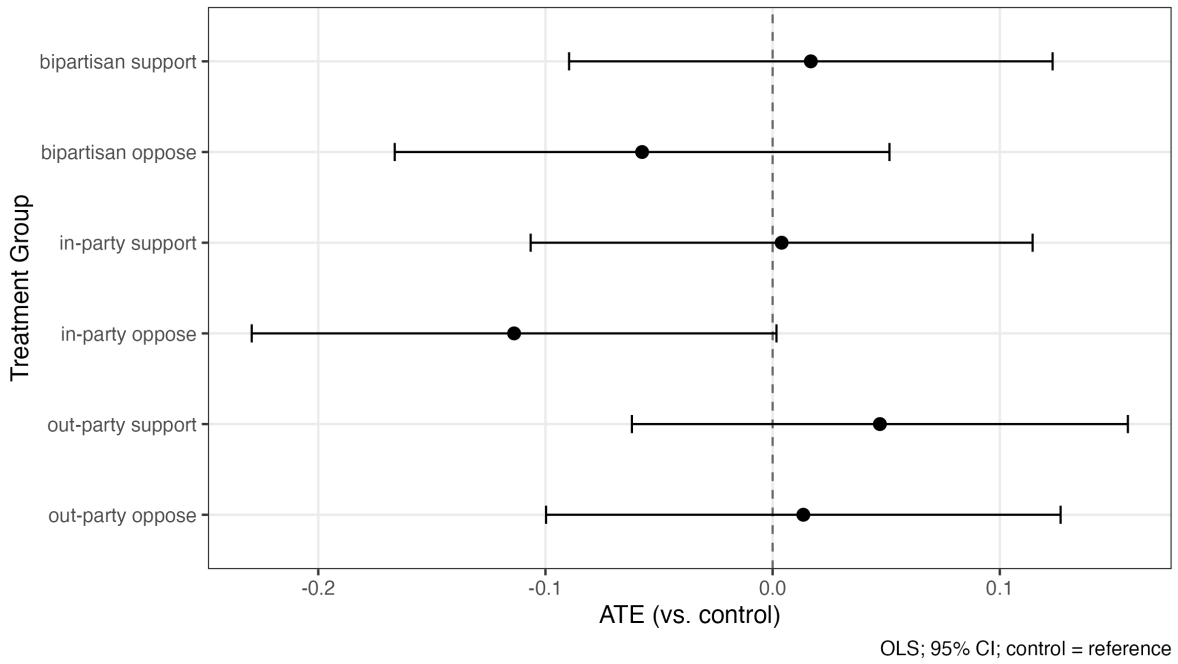


Figure 6: Effect of Partisan Cue Type by Policy Treatment

### Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support (binary) (AU)

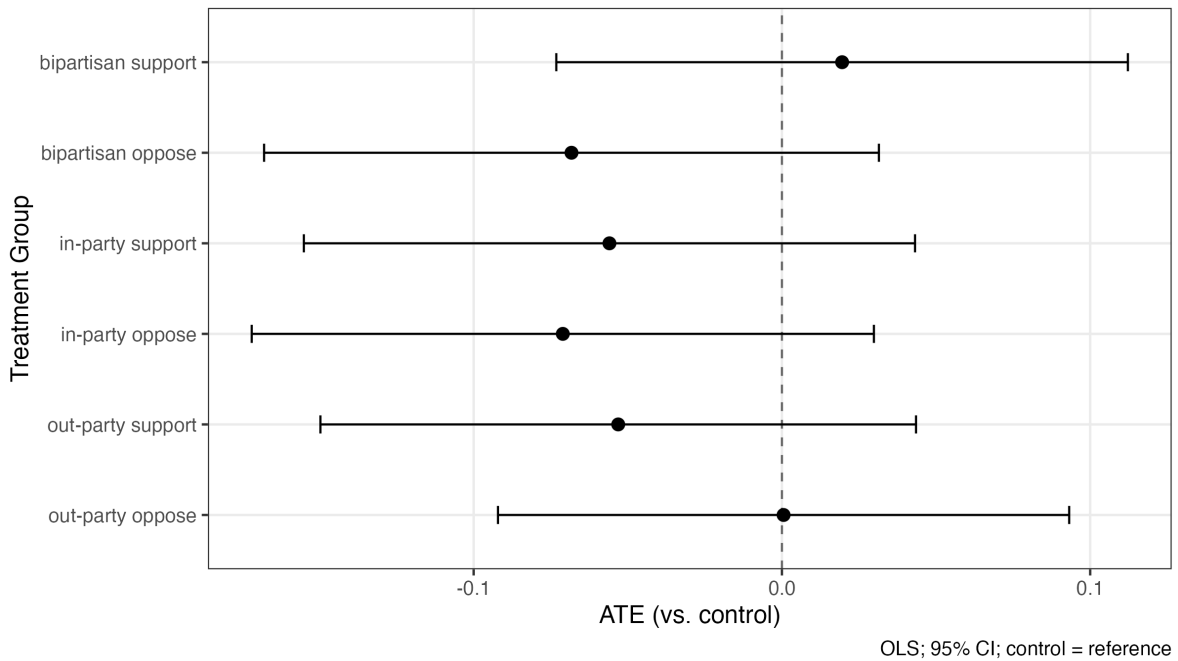


Figure 7: Effect of Partisan Cue Type by Policy Treatment

## 8 Conclusion

How do citizens form preferences towards specific trade policies? This article has argued that partisan cues play a central role in translating general trade attitudes into policy-specific preferences, and that these cues operate asymmetrically: negative signals reduce support for trade agreements, while positive signals do comparatively little to bolster it. We traced this asymmetry to the distributional structure of trade itself. Because trade liberalization generates diffuse gains but concentrated losses, negative cues heighten distributional uncertainty, prompting citizens to ask whether they or their communities might bear the concentrated costs. Positive cues, by contrast, offer reassurance about benefits that are difficult to localize to any individual's economic circumstances.

Our empirical evidence provides support for this argument, though with important caveats. Across the first two experiments, we find a consistent pattern: cues that should make respondents more hostile to a trade agreement produce substantively meaningful reductions in support. The in-party oppose cue exerts the largest effect, reducing support by 12 to 22 percentage points across experiments. Positive cues, by contrast, produce no detectable shifts in preferences across either experiment. Furthermore, we demonstrate that the equivalent negative cues do not move preferences on tax or youth employment policy, which speaks against the interpretation that the asymmetry reflects a general feature of partisan communication.

We stress, however, that not all findings replicate cleanly across waves. The information-seeking result does not replicate between the first and third experiment. In addition, while the third experiment confirms the effect of in-party opposition in the United States ( $p < 0.05$ ), bipartisan opposition and out-party support do not reach conventional levels of significance, a departure from the pattern observed in the first two waves. In Australia, we find null effects across the board, consistent with our expectation that partisan cues should be weaker in an environment where partisanship is less affectively charged—but the weaker US results in this wave merit further discussion.

One possible explanation for the divergence in the results of the third experiment is that respondents in 2026 face a changed information environment surrounding trade policy. Our theory posits that partisan cues are most effective when citizens lack independent information about a policy's dis-

tributional consequences. The third experiment was fielded between March 26th and April 6th, 2026, roughly one year after “Liberation Day,” the Trump administration’s sweeping tariff announcements that imposed new duties on imports from dozens of countries. In the year that followed, trade policy became a fixture of news coverage in ways that it had not been during the first two waves. This shift plausibly reduced the scope for partisan cues to operate. When citizens have already formed independent assessments of how trade policy affects them and their communities, the marginal informational value of a partisan cue diminishes. The fact that in-party opposition remains significant even in this environment suggests that the trust channel retains some force. The weakening of the other negative cue effects, however, is consistent with our informational condition: as citizens acquire more independent knowledge about trade, cue effects attenuate.

These findings carry important implications for the politics of trade multilateralism. If partisan cues on trade policy operate asymmetrically – capable of eroding support but not of building it – then the political environment structurally disadvantages the institutions and agreements that sustain the multilateral trading order, which is evident in the paralysis of WTO’s Appellate Body (Pauwelyn, 2023). Preferential trade agreements, WTO negotiations, and multilateral rounds all require, at minimum, public acquiescence. Proponents of these agreements face an uphill battle: positive cues from supportive elites do little to mobilize public backing, while opponents can deploy negative cues to generate distributional anxiety and erode support. Each episode of political contestation over a trade agreement has the potential to durably reduce public support, with no symmetric mechanism available to restore it. We conclude that while public support for trade in the abstract may be durable, support for the specific agreements through which trade is conducted might be far more fragile than it appears.

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## **Appendix: Tables and Figures**

|                                  | n      | mean | sd   | min   | max  |
|----------------------------------|--------|------|------|-------|------|
| outcome_support_binary_scale     | 964.00 | 0.80 | 0.39 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| outcome_support_narrow_scale     | 964.00 | 0.71 | 0.64 | -1.00 | 1.00 |
| outcome_support_full_scale       | 964.00 | 1.49 | 1.42 | -3.00 | 3.00 |
| white                            | 964.00 | 0.82 | 0.39 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| male                             | 964.00 | 0.64 | 0.48 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| college                          | 964.00 | 0.65 | 0.48 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| Democrats                        | 964.00 | 0.40 | 0.49 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| union                            | 964.00 | 0.09 | 0.29 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| unemployed                       | 964.00 | 0.03 | 0.16 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| income_low                       | 964.00 | 0.14 | 0.35 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| income_mid                       | 964.00 | 0.46 | 0.50 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| UK_warm                          | 956.00 | 0.94 | 0.24 | 0.00  | 1.00 |
| Pretreatment: Trade More         | 964.00 | 0.52 | 1.39 | -3.00 | 3.00 |
| Pretreatment: US Benefit         | 964.00 | 0.55 | 1.42 | -3.00 | 3.00 |
| Pretreatment: Personally Benefit | 964.00 | 0.07 | 1.37 | -3.00 | 3.00 |
| Pretreatment: People Benefit     | 964.00 | 0.24 | 1.32 | -3.00 | 3.00 |
| Pretreatment: Community Benefit  | 964.00 | 0.27 | 1.44 | -3.00 | 3.00 |

Table A.1: Summary Statistics

|                        | (1)               | (2)               | (3)               | (4)               | (5)               | (6)               |
|------------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
| In-party Support       | −0.005<br>(0.047) |                   |                   |                   |                   |                   |
| In-party Oppose        |                   | −0.189<br>(0.056) |                   |                   |                   |                   |
| Out-party Support      |                   |                   | −0.130<br>(0.047) |                   |                   |                   |
| Out-party Oppose       |                   |                   |                   | −0.019<br>(0.039) |                   |                   |
| Bipartisan Support     |                   |                   |                   |                   | 0.062<br>(0.036)  |                   |
| Bipartisan Oppose      |                   |                   |                   |                   |                   | −0.150<br>(0.048) |
| Democrat               | −0.016<br>(0.051) | 0.086<br>(0.061)  | 0.115<br>(0.047)  | 0.110<br>(0.041)  | 0.083<br>(0.037)  | 0.099<br>(0.044)  |
| white                  | 0.086<br>(0.079)  | 0.058<br>(0.088)  | −0.058<br>(0.067) | 0.005<br>(0.056)  | −0.065<br>(0.036) | 0.011<br>(0.070)  |
| male                   | −0.082<br>(0.051) | 0.078<br>(0.070)  | 0.042<br>(0.048)  | 0.002<br>(0.044)  | 0.057<br>(0.044)  | 0.057<br>(0.053)  |
| college                | 0.006<br>(0.051)  | 0.024<br>(0.064)  | −0.079<br>(0.050) | −0.039<br>(0.047) | −0.021<br>(0.036) | −0.067<br>(0.050) |
| unemployed             | −0.474<br>(0.253) | −0.551<br>(0.118) | −0.032<br>(0.109) | −0.806<br>(0.141) | −0.187<br>(0.136) | −0.491<br>(0.343) |
| Mid Income             | 0.004<br>(0.062)  | 0.175<br>(0.140)  | 0.029<br>(0.074)  | 0.052<br>(0.071)  | −0.033<br>(0.064) | 0.083<br>(0.081)  |
| High Income            | 0.008<br>(0.060)  | 0.174<br>(0.143)  | −0.049<br>(0.076) | 0.032<br>(0.076)  | −0.039<br>(0.062) | 0.062<br>(0.083)  |
| Feeling towards the UK | 0.192<br>(0.152)  | 0.254<br>(0.144)  | 0.511<br>(0.112)  | 0.159<br>(0.128)  | 0.222<br>(0.128)  | 0.327<br>(0.114)  |
| union                  | 0.001<br>(0.071)  | −0.098<br>(0.094) | −0.099<br>(0.084) | −0.022<br>(0.070) | −0.062<br>(0.069) | 0.013<br>(0.091)  |
| Trade.More.pre         | −0.037<br>(0.028) | 0.078<br>(0.050)  | 0.023<br>(0.034)  | 0.001<br>(0.039)  | −0.012<br>(0.025) | −0.066<br>(0.038) |
| US.Benefit.pre         | 0.095<br>(0.031)  | −0.029<br>(0.050) | −0.025<br>(0.035) | 0.016<br>(0.036)  | 0.021<br>(0.027)  | 0.076<br>(0.036)  |
| Personally.Benefit.pre | −0.013<br>(0.028) | 0.063<br>(0.050)  | −0.002<br>(0.032) | 0.039<br>(0.035)  | 0.042<br>(0.027)  | 0.032<br>(0.043)  |
| People.Benefit.pre     | −0.030<br>(0.033) | −0.055<br>(0.055) | 0.024<br>(0.038)  | −0.052<br>(0.038) | −0.057<br>(0.030) | −0.040<br>(0.045) |
| Community.Benefit.pre  | 0.046<br>(0.021)  | 0.035<br>(0.032)  | 0.061<br>(0.028)  | 0.054<br>(0.023)  | 0.048<br>(0.021)  | 0.035<br>(0.029)  |
| (Intercept)            | 0.634<br>(0.163)  | 0.302<br>(0.199)  | 0.436<br>(0.140)  | 0.679<br>(0.130)  | 0.713<br>(0.137)  | 0.713<br>(0.137)  |
| Num.Obs.               | 184               | 188               | 232               | 232               | 226               | 226               |
| R2                     | 0.202             | 0.258             | 0.261             | 0.174             | 0.162             | 0.162             |
| R2 Adj.                | 0.130             | 0.193             | 0.209             | 0.117             | 0.102             | 0.102             |

Table A.2: Regression Results (DV: Support for the US-UK agreement)

Table A.3: Effect of partisan cues on trade-agreement support

|                     | US — Binary         | US — Cardinal       | AU — Binary         | AU — Cardinal       |
|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Bipartisan support  | 0.017<br>(0.055)    | 0.030<br>(0.080)    | 0.020<br>(0.050)    | -0.002<br>(0.070)   |
| Bipartisan oppose   | -0.057<br>(0.055)   | -0.063<br>(0.079)   | -0.068<br>(0.051)   | -0.112<br>(0.070)   |
| In-party support    | 0.004<br>(0.057)    | 0.006<br>(0.082)    | -0.056<br>(0.051)   | -0.071<br>(0.070)   |
| In-party oppose     | -0.114*<br>(0.057)  | -0.178*<br>(0.082)  | -0.071<br>(0.051)   | -0.103<br>(0.071)   |
| Out-party support   | 0.047<br>(0.058)    | 0.044<br>(0.083)    | -0.053<br>(0.050)   | -0.096<br>(0.068)   |
| Out-party oppose    | 0.014<br>(0.058)    | 0.013<br>(0.085)    | 0.001<br>(0.050)    | -0.023<br>(0.068)   |
| Intercept (control) | 0.694***<br>(0.039) | 0.597***<br>(0.056) | 0.792***<br>(0.036) | 0.750***<br>(0.049) |
| Num.Obs.            | 915                 | 915                 | 1011                | 1011                |
| R2                  | 0.011               | 0.011               | 0.007               | 0.006               |
| R2 Adj.             | 0.005               | 0.004               | 0.001               | 0.000               |

\* $p < 0.05$ ; \*\* $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ .

OLS; control = reference group. Binary outcome: support = 1 if 4–5 on 5-pt scale. Cardinal outcome: support\_tri in  $\{-1, 0, +1\}$ . Standard errors in parentheses.

Table A.4: Regression Results (DV: Support for the US-JP/AU-JP agreement)



### Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support

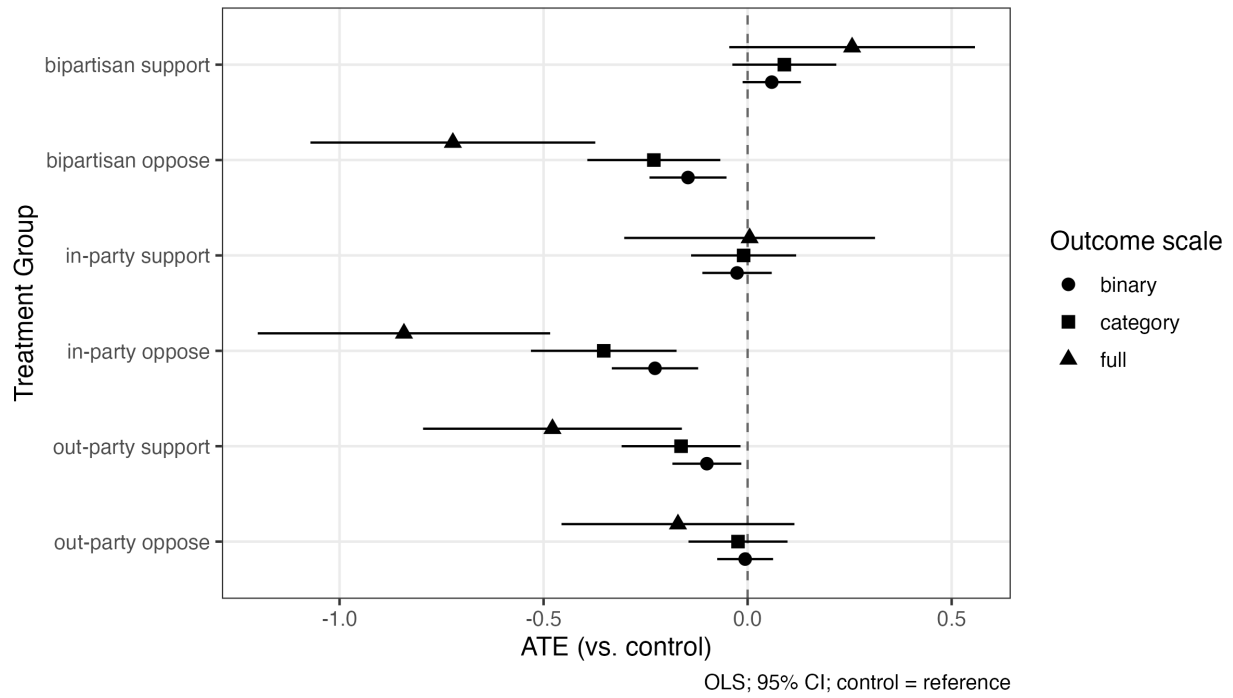


Figure A.1: Effects of Partisan Cues on Trade Agreement Preferences: Binary, Categorical, and Full Scale

Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support (cardinal) (US)

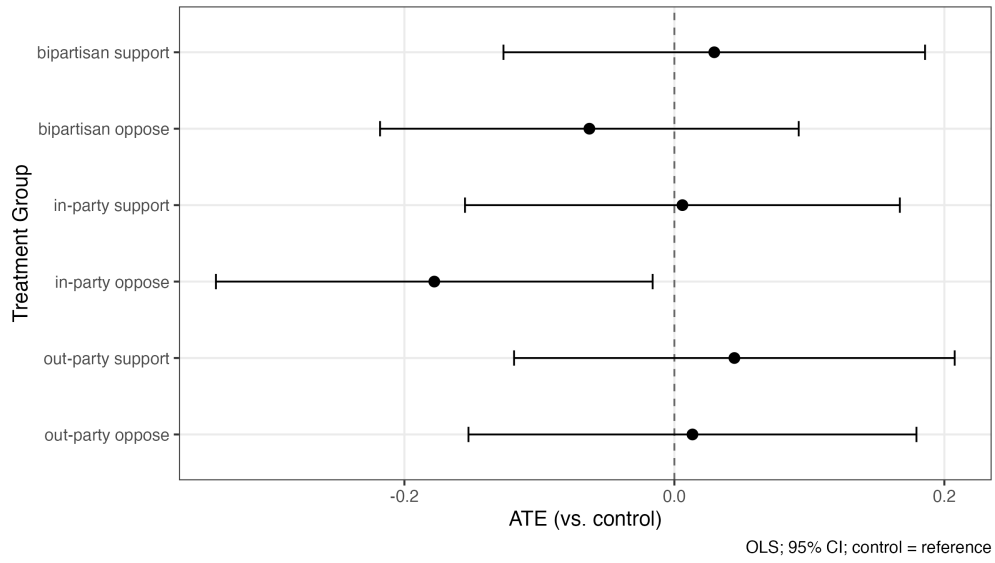


Figure A.2: ATE of Partisan Cues on Support: Cardinal Coding (US)

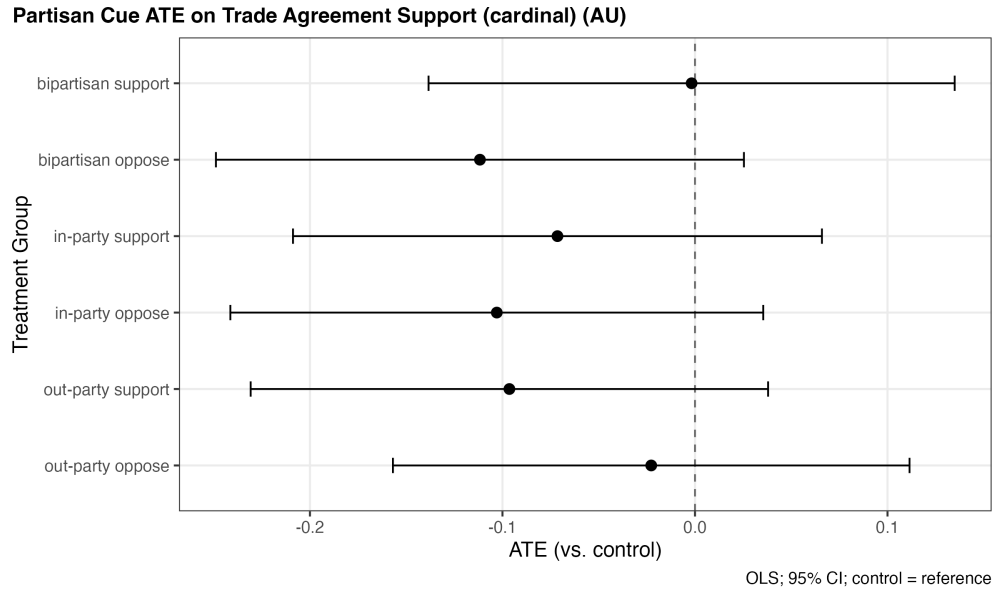


Figure A.3: ATE of Partisan Cues on Support: Cardinal Coding (AU)

If you would like to learn more about the content and effects of the US's trade agreements, we have collected a number of statements and reports, from a variety of sources, about a recent US free trade agreement (not necessarily the one you just read about). Click the boxes below if you would like to read what they had to say about it. Otherwise, click "None" to proceed to the end of the survey.

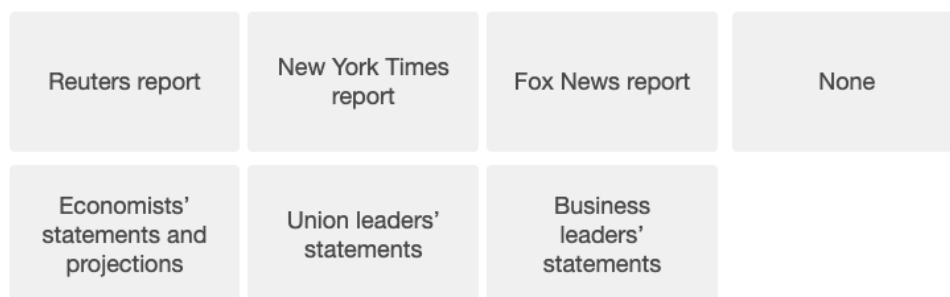


Figure A.4: Information Board

Content presented in the US Information Board are adapted from the following sources: Reuters<sup>30</sup>, New York Times<sup>31</sup>, Fox News<sup>32</sup>, Economists<sup>333435</sup>, Business Leaders<sup>36</sup>, Union Leaders<sup>37</sup>.

Content presented in the Australia Information Board are adapted from the following sources: The Sydney Morning Herald<sup>38</sup>, The Guardian<sup>39</sup>, The Herald Sun<sup>40</sup>, Economists<sup>41</sup>, Business Leaders<sup>42</sup>, Union Leaders<sup>43</sup>.

<sup>30</sup><https://www.reuters.com/article/idUSTRE6B25GJ20101204>

<sup>31</sup><https://www.nytimes.com/2010/12/04/business/global/04trade.html?searchResultPosition=8>

<sup>32</sup><https://www.foxnews.com/world/south-korea-passes-u-s-free-trade-agreement-lawmaker-sets-off-tear-ga>

<sup>33</sup><https://www.piie.com/sites/default/files/publications/pb/pb07-7.pdf>

<sup>34</sup><https://files.epi.org/2013/WorkingPaper289-2.pdf>

<sup>35</sup><https://www.everycrsreport.com/reports/R41660.html#ifn13>

<sup>36</sup><https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2010/12/03/statements-support-us-korea-trade-agreement>

<sup>37</sup><https://www.nytimes.com/2010/12/09/business/global/09trade.html>

<sup>38</sup><https://www.smh.com.au/politics/federal/australia-signs-historic-free-trade-agreement-with-south-korea-2014-02-17>

<sup>39</sup><https://www.theguardian.com/world/2014/feb/17/free-trade-deal-with-south-korea-will-help-australian>

<sup>40</sup><https://www.heraldsun.com.au/news/breaking-news/australia-inks-south-korea-free-trade-deal/news-story/a884cd8dd643561f7e2eb55fc5787adc>

<sup>41</sup>[https://www.aph.gov.au/Parliamentary\\_Business/Committees/Senate/Foreign\\_Affairs\\_Defence\\_and\\_Trade/Korea-Australia\\_Free\\_Trade\\_Agreement/Report/c03](https://www.aph.gov.au/Parliamentary_Business/Committees/Senate/Foreign_Affairs_Defence_and_Trade/Korea-Australia_Free_Trade_Agreement/Report/c03)

<sup>42</sup><https://www.bca.com.au/statement-on-the-korea-australia-free-trade-agreement>

<sup>43</sup><https://www.actu.org.au/media-release/korean-free-trade-agreement-sells-out-australian-workers/>

We presented excerpts from the above sources in the experimental survey flow, one by one, so that respondents could click on multiple links without being removed from the survey. This also allowed the authors to take time-spent and clicks-per-page measurements.

#### Partisan Cue ATE on Trade Agreement Support

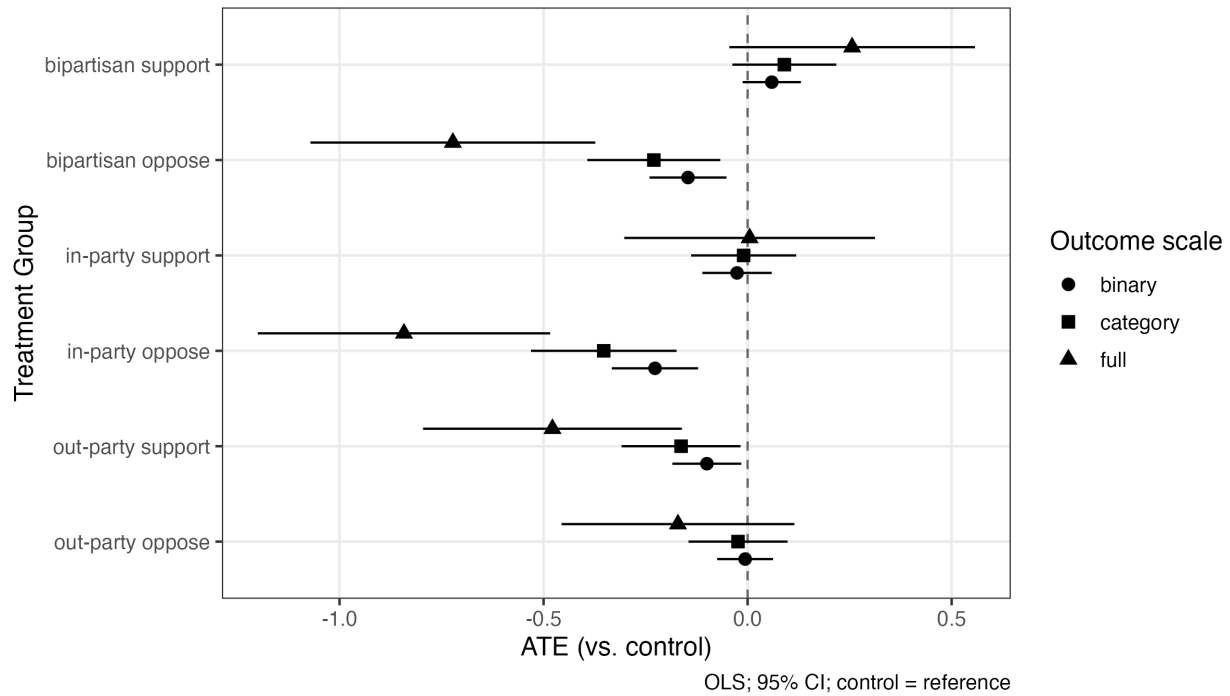


Figure A.5: Effects of Partisan Cues on Trade Agreement Preferences: Binary, Categorical, and Full Scale

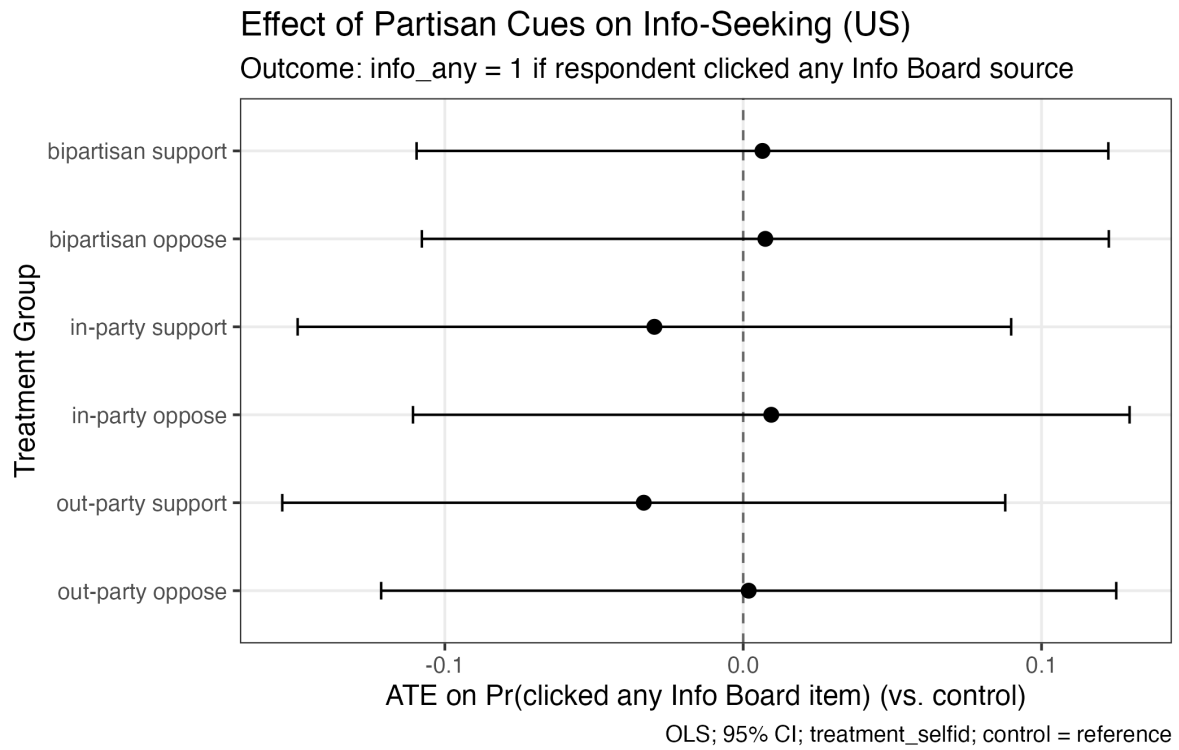


Figure A.6: Partisan Cue ATE on Infoseeking (US)

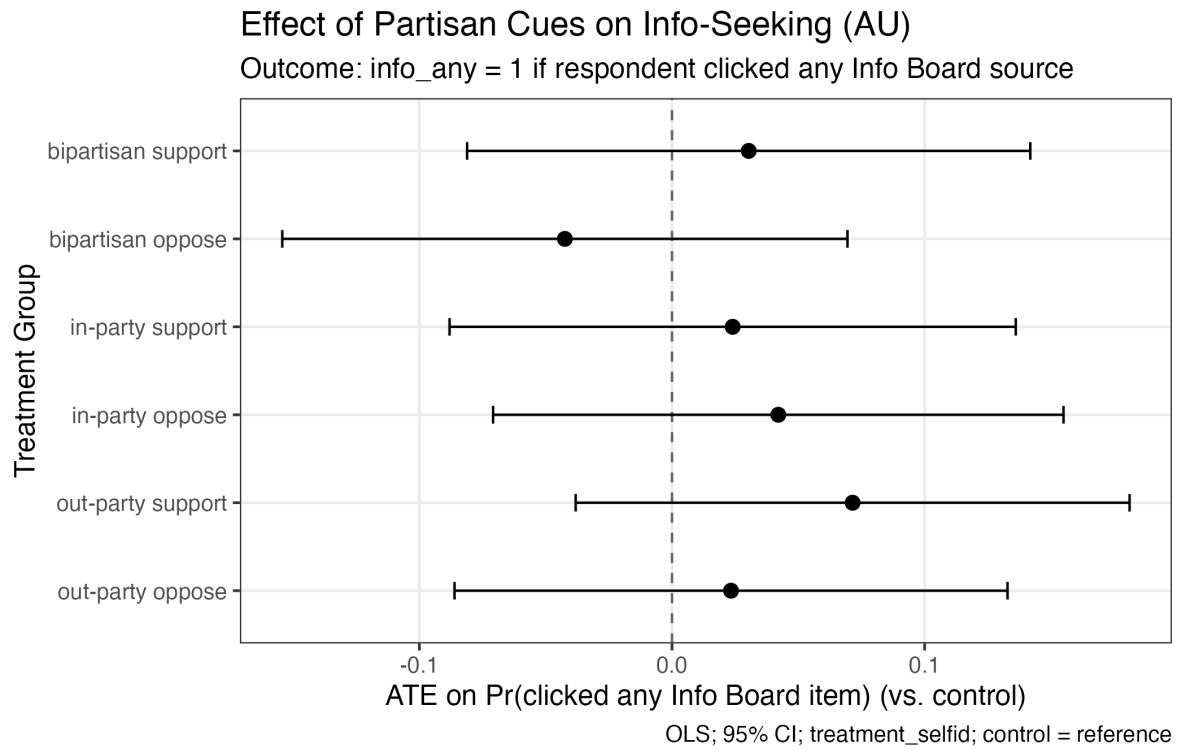


Figure A.7: Partisan Cue ATE on Infoseeking (AU)